

Research Paper

O.J. Simpson Murder Trial

Background:

The case of O.J. Simpson's murder trial is a compelling one due to its high-profile nature. A high-stake murder trial with a celebrity suspect and extensive media coverage made it a good fit for a game revolving around a criminal proceeding. O.J. Simpson was a former NFL player and actor accused of murdering his ex-wife Nicole Brown Simpson and her friend Ron Goldman. The entire trial took around 8 months from January 24 to October 3, 1995. It is generally regarded as the "most publicised" criminal trial in history.

Pre-Trial:

O.J. Simpson met Nicole Brown in 1977, getting married 8 years later and having 2 children together. Leading up to the murder, Brown had written that Simpson had been abusive, citing domestic violence on multiple occasions. Brown and Goldman were found stabbed to death near Simpson's house on June 12, 1994. Afterwards, Simpson was charged with their murders, leading to a police chase when he refused to turn himself in. He was then arraigned and pleaded not guilty, and while a grand jury was initially called, they were ultimately recused due to excessive media coverage that could impact neutrality. California Superior Court Judge Kathleen Kennedy-Powell finished the preliminary hearing by ruling that there was enough evidence was found to bring Simpson to trial, to which he pleaded "absolutely, 100 percent, not guilty". Following this, judge Lance Ito was assigned to hear the case. 304 potential jurors were interviewed, with 12 main jurors and 12 alternate jurors being chosen, and majority of the jury were African American.

Trial:

The trial itself opened in Los Angeles on 24 January 1995. The prosecution's case consisted of DNA evidence, witness testimonies & behavioural arguments. The defence on the other hand countered this by claiming mishandling of evidence, institutionalised racism in the LAPD, and reasonable doubt on the prosecution's arguments. They were also able to discredit key witnesses such as Mark Fuhrman, the detective in charge of the case on account of racism, and the lab procedures. In just 4 hours, the jury reached a not guilty verdict on 3 October 1995. This concludes the main timeline of the criminal trial. Simpson later faced civil trials together with other criminal offences.

Reflection after the Trial:

The verdict led to a racial divide, with Black Americans seeing it as justice while White Americans viewed it as a failure to uphold justice. The majority African American jury did not help the situation, as the defence played into the LAPD's racism as a core part of their strategy.

Evidence, Witnesses & Arguments

Prosecution:

1. Simpson had a history of domestic violence towards Brown, who had made a call to the police.
2. Fibers from the carpet in Simpson's Bronco were found on the glove from Simpson's apartment, as well as the crime scene itself.
3. The left glove of a pair of Aris Light gloves in a size XL was found on the crime scene, with the right side found at Simpson's apartment.
4. Shoe prints at the crime scene were from a Bruno Magli shoe in size 12, which is the same size that Simpson wore. This print matched a bloody shoe impression on his Bronco's carpet.
5. Several types of Blood evidence were found:
 - a. The killer's found at the crime scene matched Simpson's type, who had fresh cuts on his hand a day after the murder.
 - b. Simpson's Bronco had blood in it.
 - c. A trail of blood was found in Simpson's home at the driveway, foyer and master bedroom.
 - d. Brown's blood was found on socks in Simpson's home.

Mark Fuhrman: a detective involved in the case, discovered the crucial glove evidence in Simpson's home. Evidence of him making racist remarks surfaced, discrediting him. He also pleaded the Fifth, adding to the doubt.

Allan Park: the limousine driver sent to take Simpson to the airport, testified that Simpson was not at the correct place during the time of murder.

Defence:

1. The glove which was claimed to be worn by the culprit was too tight to fit Simpson's hand.
2. Racial bias found in tapes of the detective responsible for the investigation impacted the integrity of the investigation. Such remarks included:
 - a. Racist slurs and prejudice against black people.
 - b. potential motive for planting evidences.
 - c. lying under oath.
3. Simpson had an alibi during the time of the murder.
4. Physical evidences, particularly the DNA samples, were compromised due to improper handling by the LAPD. Such as:
 - a. collecting evidence without following proper protocols, leading to potential contamination.
 - b. Samples were stored in conditions that could degrade DNA integrity.
 - c. Lapses in documenting who handled the evidence resulted in questions regarding the authenticity of the samples.

Rosa Lopez: Simpson's neighbour's housekeeper, stated that she saw his Bronco outside the house at the time of the murder. Later, her statements were proven to be contradicting and inaccurate.

Dr. Henry Lee: a forensic scientist on the case, he was able to deconstruct most of the prosecution's evidence, particularly the blood evidence.

Fredric Rieders: a toxicologist who showed preservatives were present on crucial evidence, casting doubt on the evidence.

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